



MAS Admissions Policy

2026-2027

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1. Overview

Al Maaref American School (MAS) welcomes students of all nationalities, religions and abilities, who, in the school's opinion, will benefit from the academic and social learning environment we offer. Our school is committed to providing an inclusive and intercultural learning experience with a focus on global mindedness.

Your child's academic, social and personal growth is taken very seriously. To serve your child's individual needs and to support his or her transition to our school, it is important that we have complete information regarding previous academic experiences or other relevant personal insight.

MAS seeks to nurture the holistic development of every child. We seek to develop every child's talent and potential so he/she can achieve his/her greatness. We encourage you to share your child's interests, special needs, gifts and talents with us, so we can fully support his/her needs.

Parents or guardians of any applicant having a specific need must submit complete reports with their application. These might include Individualized Education Plans (IEPs) or educational evaluation and psychological reports from health professionals. In the case where a child's specific need has not been previously identified or disclosed, the school will review the information provided, in consultation with the Head of Inclusion where relevant, so that appropriate support can be planned for the student.

The school adheres to UAE law and KHDA guidelines. Please refer to the Parent School Contract.

2. Age Requirements and Grade Placement

Age eligibility follows KHDA's updated age-grade guidelines (December 2025). As MAS begins its academic year in August/September, a child's age for admission purposes is calculated as of 31 December of the year of admission. This applies from the 2026-2027 academic year onward.

Grade	Age (by 31 Dec)
KG 1	4 Years
KG 2	5 Years
GR 1	6 Years
GR 2	7 Years
GR 3	8 Years
GR 4	9 Years
GR 5	10 Years
GR 6	11 Years
GR 7	12 Years
GR 8	13 Years
GR 9	14 Years

GR 10	15 Years
GR 11	16 Years
GR 12	17 Years

For Grade 2 and above, placement is based on the grade last successfully completed at the applicant's previous school, as shown on the Transfer Certificate.

Transitional Provisions — 2026-2027 Academic Year Only

As a one-time transitional arrangement for students registering for the first time in the KHDA school system for the 2026-2027 academic year:

- Children born between 1 September and 31 December 2021 may be registered in KG1 or KG2, subject to MAS's assessment of the child's readiness and the availability of places.
- Children born between 1 September and 31 December 2022 may be registered in Pre-KG or KG1, subject to MAS's assessment of the child's readiness and the availability of places.

Students already enrolled at MAS continue in their current grade with no change.

3. Language Proficiency Entry Requirements

Kindergarten 2 (KG2) to Grade 12

The language of instruction at Al Maaref American School is English. All non-native English-speaking students admitted to MAS from KG2 to Grade 12 are expected to demonstrate near or at grade-level mastery of the English language. During the intake process, the applicant's English proficiency (speaking, reading and writing) is assessed to determine their current level and to identify the learning support they may need. Non-native English speakers whose fluency is found to be below grade level will be considered for admission together with a plan for the English language learning support required to help them access the curriculum.

4. Admissions Procedures

Applications for admission are always accepted during the school year, although there are cut-off dates during the year which may prevent admission, as designated by the UAE Ministry of Education.

Applications must be completed, If there are no places available at the time, the application is placed onto the school's waiting list. When a place becomes available, the school will contact the first eligible applicant and invite them to attend an assessment.

Selection Criteria

Selection is based on multiple criteria, used to build a full picture of the applicant and the support they may need. These include:

- Priority given to siblings of students who have secured admission to the school.
- Results of the English language baseline assessment (even where English is the applicant's native tongue), used to understand the applicant's current level and any language support required — this is not treated as a simple pass/fail measure.
- For KG1-KG2 applicants, an assessment of school readiness, including toilet training and a level of independence appropriate to the age group.
- Past school results and reports.
- Full details of any special education needs and individual education plans (IEPs), plus educational psychologist's reports if completed — provided to help the school plan appropriate support, not to determine eligibility.
- A face-to-face interview with the section Assistant Principal or other designated school staff.
- Age appropriateness for the year/grade level to which admission is sought.
- Transfer certificate from the previous school.
- For students entering high school (Grades 10-12), a valid transcript from their previous school.
- The child's previous curriculum, as well as any limitations regarding transfer dates for local transfers.
- Reasonable accommodations will be made available during assessments and interviews for any applicant who requires them, including applicants with identified or suspected additional needs.

Conditional Offers of a Place at MAS

You may be offered a conditional placement at MAS. This means that the school needs further information, documentation, or a short period of time to confirm the most effective support arrangements before your child's place is fully confirmed. A conditional offer is never used as a way of refusing admission because of a student's disability or additional needs. You may be asked to provide or sign:

- Further documentation about your child's schooling.
- Evidence of application for residency, or your residency status.
- Consent for an educational psychologist's assessment or other evaluation, where this is needed to help plan the right support for your child.
- Agreement to a short settling-in period, during which the school and family will review together the support in place and agree on any adjustments needed.

5. Entrance Assessment

All invited applicants from Grade 3 to Grade 12 complete an English language baseline assessment (MAP screening, computer-based), while KG1 to Grade 2 applicants take part in an age-appropriate interview with the section principal.

These assessments are used to understand each applicant's current level of English and academic skills, so that the school can plan appropriate placement, transition support and, where needed, learning support — they are not used as a simple pass/fail measure of eligibility.

6. Admission Requirements

- Completion of the school's entrance assessment in English.
- Applicant's age, in line with the grade placement table above.

Submission of the following documents:

- 3 recent coloured passport-size photographs.
- Copy of the birth certificate.
- Original vaccination card from Grade 1 to Grade 12 (not COVID vaccination).
- Copy of the student's passport with a valid residence visa for non-UAE citizens.
- Original Emirates ID from students and parents.
- The student's last 3 years' report cards from the school last attended. If transferring from a school outside the UAE, the report must be attested by the Ministry of Education, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and the UAE consulate in the country where the school was located.
- For other Emirates (except Dubai) — Ministry of Education attestation only.
- Transfer certificate attested by the school last attended, for transfers from a school located outside Dubai.
- Photocopy of immunization records.
- Admission fee **AED 500**, non-refundable and non-deductible, charged only after approval of the applicant.
- Registration fee of **AED 1000**, deductible from the total fees.

7. Identification as Students of Determination — Inclusion

In alignment with Federal Law 29 (2006), Law No. 2 (2014), and the Dubai Inclusive Education Policy Framework (2019) regarding the education and outcomes of individuals with Special Educational Needs and Disabilities, MAS welcomes applications from all students, including Students of Determination.

MAS will not refuse admission to a Student of Determination solely on the basis of their identified needs or disability. The purpose of our admissions process is to understand each applicant's needs and to plan the reasonable adjustments and support required for them to access our curriculum and school life. The aim is to promote inclusion so that children with special educational needs can achieve their full learning potential through access to a broad, balanced, creative and challenging curriculum with a wide variety of opportunities and experiences.

To understand individual needs and to support Students of Determination, parents should provide the school with complete information regarding previous academic experience, formal assessments, and psychometric and/or medical reports if available, so that the school can plan the most effective pathway and support for the student from the point of enrolment.

The school has appropriate procedures in place to identify Students of Determination at the point of entry. Where a student is identified, or suspected, to have additional learning needs at any point in the assessment process, the Head of Inclusion will review the application, meet with the family, and work with the Learning Support team to plan the support required before enrolment.

Additional Procedures for Students with Identified or Suspected Additional Needs (KG – Grade 12)

Where a student is identified or suspected to have additional needs during the admission process, the following procedures may apply, as appropriate to the student's age, grade level, and individual needs:

- An interview with the **Head of Inclusion and/or Learning Support Team**, supported by age-appropriate observation or play-based interaction where appropriate.
- Additional evidence may be used to better understand the student's academic, communication, behavioural, developmental, or functional needs.
- Where further clarification is required, the **Head of Inclusion may request an educational, psychological and/or medical report from an appropriately qualified professional** to better understand the student's needs and determine the appropriate support and reasonable adjustments
- Additional evidence may include a home video of the child's interactions and speech, should the child be hesitant in a formal interview.

Individual Learning Support Assistant (1:1 LSA) – Safety and Safeguarding

Where documented observations or risk assessment identify significant concerns regarding a student's **safety, safeguarding, independence, or risk of harm to themselves or others**, the school may require a **temporary Individual Learning Support Assistant (1:1 LSA)** as part of the student's support and transition plan.

Where applicable, the 1:1 LSA may be provided at the parents’/guardians’ expense. This requirement will be based on the student’s **individual assessed needs and safety considerations, not on disability or diagnosis alone.**

The need for 1:1 support will be **regularly reviewed** based on the student’s progress, independence, safety, and ability to access the school environment successfully. The support may be reduced or discontinued when it is no longer required.

Exceptional Cases

MAS's starting position is that a Student of Determination will not be refused admission because of their identified needs or disability. In the rare event that the school does not, even with reasonable adjustments, have the ability to meet a specific applicant's needs safely and appropriately, a decision not to proceed with admission will only be made after:

- A meeting between the family, the Head of Inclusion, and the school principal to discuss the applicant's needs and the support MAS can put in place.
- Full consideration of the reasonable adjustments that could enable the student to access the curriculum and school life.
- Consultation with KHDA, in line with its inclusive education procedures, before any final decision is made.

Any decision not to proceed with admission on this basis will be communicated to the family in writing, with reasons, and will be reviewed and approved by the school principal.

8. The Admissions Process

The process outlined below is managed and administered by the Admissions department, in collaboration and consultation with the principal and, where a student has identified or suspected additional needs, the Head of Inclusion.

Application submitted
Invitation for assessment
Assessment / interview conducted to identify level, placement and support needs
Outcome and recommended support plan shared with parents
Parent informed and invited to register
Documentation processed

Student file prepared
Initial fee payment taken
Student enrolled

9. Process Length

The admission process for each child is completed within 3-5 working days of the assessment, for students based in Dubai.

To achieve this goal, the following process and service standards have been defined:

- Receiving assessment/interview results the same day and informing parents directly.
- Responding to parents after receiving the results within 24-48 hours, only in special cases.

10. Registration & Selection Process

- Following assessment, school management decides whether a place is to be offered, based on all information gathered through the assessment and application.
- The decision taken by the school is final and all admissions follow the guidelines and regulations set by the KHDA.
- Parents must respond to an offer within 3 days of receipt to secure the place. A child's place is held only once the deposit fee has been paid to the Accounts department. If the desired grade level becomes full, the child is placed on a waiting list, generated on a first-come, first-served basis.
- Prior to admission, a Transfer Certificate (attested where required) must be submitted.

11. Registration and Admission Fees

The registration and admission fees are regulated as follows:

Existing students

A 5% deposit of the school's tuition fees confirms the return of existing students in the new academic year. This deposit is deducted from the total tuition fees for the academic year in which admission is being sought.

New students

A 10% admission fee of the school's tuition fees confirms that selected students will take up the offered places. This fee is deducted from the total tuition fees for the academic year in which admission is being sought.

Refund

For both existing and new students, deposits and fees are not refunded if a student chooses not to return to school for the next academic year, or chooses not to take up the offered place. However, the school will refund the deposit under special circumstances. These include, but are not limited to, evidence of family relocation to another country, a move to another Emirate, or other unforeseen circumstances. Such cases may be submitted to KHDA for review.

In the case of refund and recovery, school fees will be calculated as follows:

- If the student attends school for two weeks or less, one month's fees will be deducted.
- If the student attends school for between two weeks and one month, two months' fees will be deducted.
- If the student attends for more than a month, three months' fees will be deducted.

12. Notice of Leaving

Where fees remain unpaid, students are not entitled to receive a transfer certificate or their final reports until fees have been paid.

For matters not otherwise addressed in this policy, the principal's decision is final in all matters of admission, in line with KHDA regulations — with the exception of decisions relating to the admission of a Student of Determination, which follow the process set out in Section 7 (Exceptional Cases).

Annual Policy Review

This policy is reviewed annually; any deficiencies or weaknesses identified in admissions will be remedied without delay. The Principal, Head of Inclusion, and Director of Admissions undertake an annual review of the admissions policies and procedures, and of the efficiency with which related duties have been discharged.

MAS Administration